

Your guide to clinical trials



In this leaflet

In this leaflet you'll find out:

- what clinical trials are
- how you can take part
- what questions to ask

Visit
cruk.org/trials
to find out more





What is a clinical trial?

Clinical trials are medical research involving people. They help us to understand more about cancer, including:

- the causes of cancer
- symptoms and screening
- diagnosing cancer
- treating cancer
- living with cancer

Trials are a routine part of cancer care. There are lots of different types, including:

- trying a new medicine or treatment
- giving samples like blood or tissue
- filling in a questionnaire
- having tests or a new test

You might be involved in a trial for just one appointment, or over a few years.

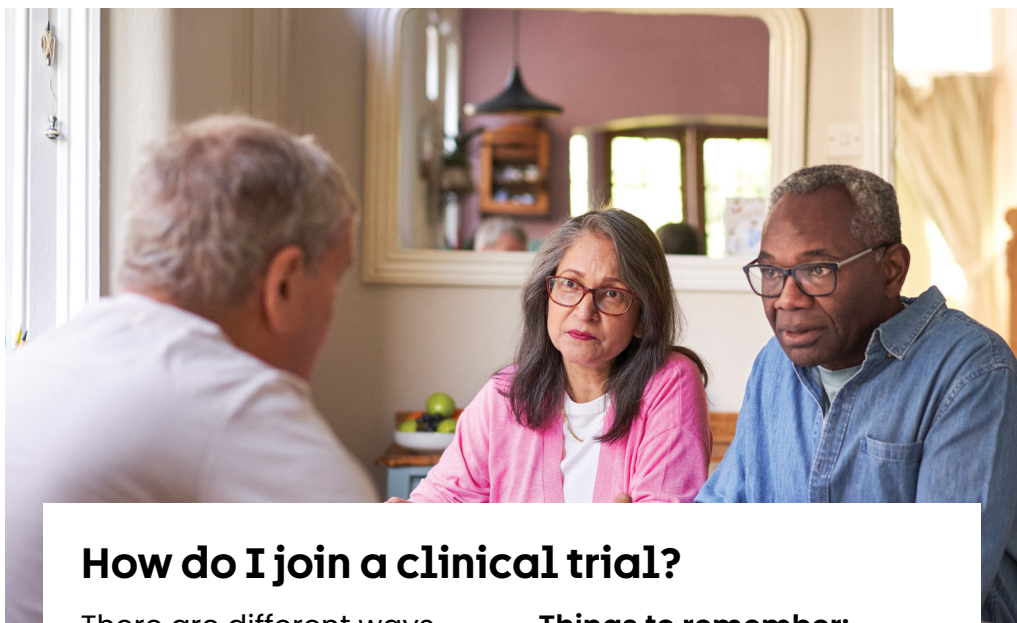
Why do we do clinical trials?

Trials are the only reliable way to find out if a new test or treatment:

- is safe
- works better than the current test or treatment
- has side effects
- helps you feel better

They help us to improve care and treatment for people with cancer, now and in the future.

'Clinical trial', 'clinical research' and 'research study' all mean the same thing.



How do I join a clinical trial?

There are different ways you can get involved in a clinical trial:

- Your specialist or a research nurse might contact you if there's a trial that might be suitable for you.
- You can speak to your cancer specialist. They can tell you which trials are running at your hospital or refer you to another hospital.

If there's a suitable trial, your specialist or research nurse will explain things in more detail and give you written information. You'll have to sign a consent form if you decide to take part.

Things to remember:

- Information about trials can be complicated, so ask if there's anything you don't understand.
- Discussing a trial with family or friends can help you decide if you want to take part.
- You don't have to take part in a trial if you don't want to.
- You can leave a clinical trial at any time without giving a reason.

Our clinical trials database has information about more than 2,800 clinical trials from the UK.

Visit **cruk.org/trials** to find out more.



Are clinical trials safe?

Your safety is very important. Your research team will monitor you closely, but there are some risks with any clinical trial. The possible risks and benefits will be clearly explained to you.

What are the benefits?

- You may have a treatment that's only available in a clinical trial.
- You may have more check-ups, tests or scans than usual, which you might find reassuring.

- You'll be helping to improve cancer treatments and care for future patients.

What are the drawbacks?

- You may have to make more trips to hospital.
- The extra tests and check-ups could increase your worry about cancer.
- You may have to do some paperwork.



What should I ask?

Here's a list of questions you could ask your specialist or research team if you're interested in a clinical trial:

- Why are you doing this trial?
- Has this treatment been used before?
- How long will I have the treatment for?
- Will I benefit from this trial?
- Are there any risks or side effects?
- Will I have any extra hospital appointments or tests?
- Will I need to stay in hospital?
- How long is the follow up?
- What happens to my care if I withdraw from the trial?
- What will you do with any information you collect about me?
- Will I get any results?
- Will I be paid?
- Will this affect my travel or health insurance?
- Who can I contact if I have any questions?



Susan's story

Susan was diagnosed with bowel cancer after noticing a change in her bowel habits. She had a successful operation to remove her tumour in May 2016.

She's since joined the Add-Aspirin clinical trial. This is looking at whether taking aspirin after treatment can stop cancer coming back.

She says: "I agreed to take part in the hope it would help with research and anyone else who was facing the same diagnosis.

I'd advise anyone who is offered a place on a trial to consider joining. I felt I had a safety net because after I'd been discharged from hospital I'd felt very alone, anxious and afraid that the cancer would return. It gave me great peace of mind knowing I was being monitored on a regular basis."

Cancer Research UK and clinical trials



We currently support hundreds of clinical trials looking into treatments and tests for cancer. This is part of our commitment to understand cancer better and make sure laboratory research moves through clinical trials to improve the lives of people affected by cancer.

For more information

Visit **cruk.org/trials**

You can use our online clinical trials database to find out about clinical trials in your area.

Visit **cruk.org/about-cancer**

Written specially for people affected by cancer, our information covers all aspects of cancer, from diagnosis to treatment and living beyond cancer.

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Cancer Research UK is a registered charity in England and Wales (1089464), Scotland (SC041666), the Isle of Man (1103) and Jersey (247).

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Chat online

Visit **cruk.org.uk/cancerchat**

to share information and experiences with others living with cancer in our online community.

Ask our nurses

You can speak to our specialist nurses on freephone **0808 800 4040**, Monday to Friday, 9am to 5pm.

My research nurse

